Choral response

Rehearsing brief answers together

Use choral response for brief, unambiguous answers that benefit from shared rehearsal. Teach a precise cue so students begin together rather than copying the earliest voice.

How to do it well

1 Choose suitable content. Use choral response for a brief fact, phrase, pronunciation, definition or completed step with one clear answer—not an extended explanation.

2 State and model the routine. Teach the cue, expected volume and complete response; model difficult vocabulary before the class attempts it.

3 Ask, think, cue. Pose the prompt, allow silent retrieval and give one unambiguous signal so every voice begins together.

4 Listen for participation and accuracy. Attend to timing, confidence and the content of the response; reset if voices are missing or the response is ragged.

5 Affirm or correct immediately. Name what was accurate, or provide the correct answer with a brief explanation and have the class repeat it precisely.

6 Check individuals when needed. Follow with cold call, mini-whiteboards or a process question; a chorus cannot by itself prove each pupil understands.

What this sounds like

“Think first. On ‘everyone in three, two, one’, say the missing word together. Plants take in carbon… Everyone in three, two, one.”

Classroom example. A Languages teacher rehearses a short phrase on a common cue after protected thinking time. The teacher listens for accurate pronunciation and repeats the troublesome part. A later individual written response checks the meaning. The chorus supports shared rehearsal without being treated as evidence that every pupil independently understands the phrase.

Top tips that make the technique work

Choose a bounded response. A key term, short fact or agreed phrase works better than an open explanation.

Build thinking before the cue. Students should know the answer they intend to give before the chorus starts.

Rehearse with easy content. Establish the mechanics separately from challenging subject knowledge.

Listen for accuracy. A loud chorus can hide missing, delayed or incorrect responses.

Use another check for diagnosis. When you need individual evidence, follow with a board response, written answer or targeted sample.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Use a consistent, rehearsed response cue.	Treating volume as proof of individual understanding.
Keep answers short and precise.	Using an ambiguous prompt with several possible responses.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Choral Response | Barton - Call and Respond